

Causes of the Great War (1871–1914)

KNOWLEDGE RETRIEVAL, HOMEWORK COMPANION & ASSESSMENT ARCHITECT

Scholar: _____ Form: _____ Teacher: **Mr Lovett** Target: _____

FORMATIVE HOMEWORK & RETRIEVAL LEDGER

DESK INSPECTION READY • 30-SECOND CHECK

LESSON / HISTORICAL TOPIC	ATT 1	ATT 2	RETRIEVAL STRENGTH	PARENT	STAFF
1. German Unification & Bismarck	/ 8	/ 8	[] Instant [] Effortful [] Restudy		[]
2. Franco-Prussian War & Revanche	/ 8	/ 8	[] Instant [] Effortful [] Restudy		[]
3. Scramble for Africa & Morocco	/ 8	/ 8	[] Instant [] Effortful [] Restudy		[]
4. Naval Arms Race & Dreadnought	/ 8	/ 8	[] Instant [] Effortful [] Restudy		[]
5. Alliance System & Powder Keg	/ 8	/ 8	[] Instant [] Effortful [] Restudy		[]
6. Sarajevo & The July Crisis	/ 8	/ 8	[] Instant [] Effortful [] Restudy		[]

Unit Mastery Target: 42+ / 48 (87%+) • *Level 4 Factual Fluency*

Mastery Score: ____ / 48



Digital Revision Portal: Scan code on a mobile device or tablet to practice interactive retrieval, flashcard vaults, and listen to spoken teacher guides.

Teacher Homework Inspection & Feedback: _____ Signature & Date _____

MASTER CHRONOLOGY DOMINO FLOWCHART

1871–1914 • 11 Anchor Flashpoints from German Unification to Continental War

DOMINO FLOWCHART

1871 **German Empire Proclaimed:** Unified in the Hall of Mirrors at Versailles; Alsace-Lorraine annexed from France, sparking lifelong French *Revanche*.

1882 **Triple Alliance Formed:** Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy create a central defensive military pact.

1890 **Bismarck Dismissed:** Kaiser Wilhelm II rejects defensive diplomacy, cancels the Reinsurance Treaty, and launches aggressive *Weltpolitik*.

1894 **Franco-Russian Alliance:** France and Russia unite militarily, trapping Germany between two rival powers (the two-front encirclement nightmare).

1898–1900 **Tirpitz Naval Laws:** Germany begins building the High Seas Fleet to challenge the British Royal Navy's supremacy.

1904 **Entente Cordiale Signed:** Britain and France settle colonial disputes (Egypt & Morocco) and begin joint defensive military discussions.

1905–1906 **First Moroccan Crisis:** Wilhelm II lands at Tangier to test the Entente; the Algeiras Conference (1906) isolates Germany and binds Britain to France.

1906 **HMS Dreadnought Launched:** Revolutionary British all-big-gun battleship resets naval technology and intensifies the Anglo-German arms race.

1907 **Triple Entente Completed:** The Anglo-Russian Convention settles Asian colonial rivalries, uniting Britain, France, and Russia.

1908 **The Bosnian Crisis:** Austria-Hungary annexes Bosnia, permanently alienating Serbia and humiliating Tsarist Russia.

28 Jun – 4 Aug 1914 **The July Crisis & War:** Franz Ferdinand assassinated in Sarajevo → German Blank Cheque → Austrian Ultimatum → Russian mobilisation → Schlieffen Plan → World War.

LESSON 1: GERMAN UNIFICATION & ALLIANCES

Direct Active Recall • Factual Core & Causal Explanation

Score: / 8

Q1-Q8

Instructions: Complete Line 1 (Answer) from memory. Complete Line 2 (The Explanation) to explain the historical mechanism, motive, or consequence.

1. How many independent states existed in Central Europe before German unification?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

2. Which powerful military kingdom led the unification of Germany?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

3. Who was the Prussian Chancellor who engineered the unification of Germany?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

4. In what year was the German Empire officially proclaimed?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

5. Where was King Wilhelm I of Prussia crowned as the first German Emperor?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

6. What was Bismarck's primary foreign policy goal after 1871?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

7. What was Germany's greatest strategic military nightmare?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

8. What secret 1887 agreement did Bismarck negotiate to keep Russia neutral?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

LESSON 2: FRANCO-PRUSSIAN WAR & REVANCHE

Direct Active Recall • Factual Core & Causal Explanation

Score: / 8

Q9–Q16

Instructions: Complete Line 1 (Answer) from memory. Complete Line 2 (The Explanation) to explain the historical mechanism, motive, or consequence.

9. Which French territory was annexed by Germany following the war in 1871?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

10. What was the French national desire for vengeance called?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

11. What was the size of the financial indemnity France was forced to pay Germany in 1871?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

12. Which treaty formally concluded the Franco-Prussian War in May 1871?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

13. Which French Emperor was captured by Prussian forces at the Battle of Sedan (1870)?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

14. Which ambitious young Emperor took the German throne in 1888 and dismissed Bismarck in 1890?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

15. What catastrophic diplomatic decision did Wilhelm II make immediately after dismissing Bismarck?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

16. What historic military alliance was signed in 1894 as a direct result of Wilhelm II's blunder?

[] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

LESSON 3: SCRAMBLE FOR AFRICA & MOROCCO

Direct Active Recall • Factual Core & Causal Explanation

Score: / 8

Q17–Q24

Instructions: Complete Line 1 (Answer) from memory. Complete Line 2 (The Explanation) to explain the historical mechanism, motive, or consequence.

17. What term describes the rapid partition of the African continent by European empires (1881–1914)? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

18. Which 1884–85 conference laid down the imperial ground rules for annexing African territory? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

19. What famous slogan expressed Kaiser Wilhelm II's demand for a German colonial empire? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

20. What was Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive global foreign policy called? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

21. Where did Kaiser Wilhelm II land in 1905 to provoke the First Moroccan Crisis? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

22. Which 1906 conference resolved the First Moroccan Crisis, resulting in a diplomatic humiliation for Germany? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

23. What military action sparked the Second Moroccan Crisis (Agadir Crisis) in 1911? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

24. What was the decisive strategic consequence of the two Moroccan Crises for Anglo-French relations? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

LESSON 4: NAVAL ARMS RACE & DREADNOUGHT

Direct Active Recall • Factual Core & Causal Explanation

Score: / 8

Q25–Q32

Instructions: Complete Line 1 (Answer) from memory. Complete Line 2 (The Explanation) to explain the historical mechanism, motive, or consequence.

25. Which revolutionary, all-big-gun British battleship was launched in 1906? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

26. Which German naval minister directed the rapid construction of the German High Seas Fleet? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

27. What traditional maritime doctrine required Britain's fleet to equal the combined strength of the next two largest navies? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

28. What was Admiral Tirpitz's 'Risk Theory' (Risikotheorie)? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

29. What was the political slogan shouted by the British public demanding more battleships in 1909? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

30. What canal did Germany deepen between 1907 and 1914 to allow dreadnoughts to pass from the Baltic to the North Sea? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

31. How many Dreadnought-class battleships had Britain and Germany built by August 1914? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

32. Why did the invention of HMS Dreadnought ironically endanger Britain's naval supremacy? [] Mastered

Answer:
The Explanation:

LESSON 5: ALLIANCE SYSTEM & BALKAN POWDER KEG

Direct Active Recall • Factual Core & Causal Explanation

Score: / 8

Q33–Q40

Instructions: Complete Line 1 (Answer) from memory. Complete Line 2 (The Explanation) to explain the historical mechanism, motive, or consequence.

33. Which three empires formed the Triple Alliance in 1882? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

34. What term describes Britain's 19th-century policy of avoiding permanent European military alliances? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

35. What friendly diplomatic accord did Britain and France sign in 1904? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

36. What 1907 agreement settled colonial rivalries in Persia, Tibet, and Afghanistan, completing the Triple Entente? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

37. Why was Italy widely viewed as the 'weak link' in the Triple Alliance? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

38. What was the fatal structural flaw of the European alliance system? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

39. Why was south-eastern Europe known as the 'Powder Keg of Europe'? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

40. Which international crisis in 1908 brought Austria-Hungary and Russia to the brink of war? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

LESSON 6: SARAJEVO ASSASSINATION & JULY CRISIS

Direct Active Recall • Factual Core & Causal Explanation

Score: / 8

Q41–Q48

Instructions: Complete Line 1 (Answer) from memory. Complete Line 2 (The Explanation) to explain the historical mechanism, motive, or consequence.

41. On what exact date was Archduke Franz Ferdinand assassinated in Sarajevo? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

42. Who was the 19-year-old Bosnian Serb nationalist who fired the fatal shots? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

43. What clandestine Serbian military terrorist organisation trained and armed the assassins? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

44. Why did Austria-Hungary's annexation of Bosnia in 1908 cause fury in Serbia? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

45. What was Germany's famous 'Blank Cheque' issued on 5–6 July 1914? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

46. What diplomatic document did Austria-Hungary deliver to Serbia on 23 July 1914? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

47. What was the German war strategy designed to prevent a prolonged two-front war? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

48. Why did Great Britain officially declare war on Germany at 11:00 pm on 4 August 1914? [] Mastered

Answer:

The Explanation:

DEPARTMENT MARKING BANK (PART 1)

Lessons 1 to 3 • Answers 1 to 24 • Core Answers & The Explanation

MARKING KEY 1–24

LESSON 1: GERMAN UNIFICATION & ALLIANCES

1. 39 independent states — Prior to 1871, the German states were loosely connected in the German Confederation, dominated by Prussia and Austria.	[✓][X]
2. Prussia — Prussia used its disciplined military, advanced railway network, and Krupp steel industry to unite the German states under Berlin.	[✓][X]
3. Otto von Bismarck — Bismarck used a pragmatic policy of 'Blood and Iron' (Realpolitik) and three swift wars to achieve unification.	[✓][X]
4. 1871 — The Empire was proclaimed following Prussia's crushing victory over France in the Franco-Prussian War.	[✓][X]
5. The Hall of Mirrors at Versailles — Staging the coronation inside the historic palace of the French monarchy was a calculated insult that deepened French hatred.	[✓][X]
6. To isolate France and maintain European peace — Bismarck knew a revanchist France could never be reconciled, so he built alliances to deny France any military partners.	[✓][X]
7. A war on two fronts (Encirclement) — Germany feared being simultaneously attacked by France from the west and Russia from the east, dividing its armed forces.	[✓][X]
8. The Reinsurance Treaty — Both powers promised neutrality unless Germany attacked France or Russia attacked Germany's ally, Austria-Hungary.	[✓][X]

LESSON 2: FRANCO-PRUSSIAN WAR & REVANCHE

9. Alsace-Lorraine — Germany seized this mineral-rich border territory for defence and industry, creating an enduring French determination to reclaim it.	[✓][X]
10. Revanche (Revanchism) — French school textbooks, maps (veiled in black), and politicians kept the loss of Alsace-Lorraine alive as an open wound.	[✓][X]
11. 5 billion gold francs — Germany intended the indemnity to cripple France economically for a generation, though France paid it off ahead of schedule.	[✓][X]
12. The Treaty of Frankfurt — The treaty codified the annexation of Alsace-Lorraine, the indemnity, and German military occupation until payment was complete.	[✓][X]
13. Napoleon III — His capture brought the immediate collapse of the French Second Empire and the proclamation of the French Third Republic.	[✓][X]
14. Kaiser Wilhelm II — Wilhelm II rejected Bismarck's cautious European diplomacy in favour of personal autocratic rule and aggressive global expansion.	[✓][X]
15. He allowed the Reinsurance Treaty with Russia to lapse — This alienated Tsar Alexander III and left Russia diplomatically isolated and seeking new European partners.	[✓][X]
16. The Franco-Russian Military Alliance — Autocratic Russia and republican France united militarily, realizing Bismarck's worst nightmare of a two-front encirclement.	[✓][X]

LESSON 3: SCRAMBLE FOR AFRICA & MOROCCO

17. The Scramble for Africa — European powers colonised 90% of Africa in search of raw industrial materials, prestige, and captive colonial markets.	[✓][X]
18. The Berlin Conference — Hosted by Bismarck, it established the principle of 'effective occupation' to prevent European wars over African land.	[✓][X]
19. A 'place in the sun' (Platz an der Sonne) — Wilhelm II argued that Germany's massive industrial and military power entitled it to a worldwide overseas empire matching Britain's.	[✓][X]
20. Weltpolitik (World Policy) — Weltpolitik abandoned Bismarck's continental focus and sought global naval, colonial, and commercial dominance.	[✓][X]
21. Tangier — He delivered a fiery speech backing the Moroccan Sultan to challenge French dominance and test the strength of the Anglo-French Entente.	[✓][X]
22. The Algeiras Conference — Only Austria-Hungary supported Germany; Britain, Russia, and Italy stood firmly with France, cementing German isolation.	[✓][X]
23. Germany sent the gunboat SMS Panther to the port of Agadir — Germany attempted 'gunboat diplomacy' to extract French colonial territory in the Congo in exchange for recognizing France in Morocco.	[✓][X]
24. It forged secret Anglo-French joint military and naval planning — Rather than driving Britain and France apart, German belligerence convinced Britain that Germany was a dangerous rogue power.	[✓][X]

DEPARTMENT MARKING BANK (PART 2)

Lessons 4 to 6 • Answers 25 to 48 • Core Answers & The Explanation

MARKING KEY 25–48

LESSON 4: NAVAL ARMS RACE & DREADNOUGHT

25. HMS Dreadnought — Dreadnought featured ten 12-inch guns and turbine propulsion, making every existing battleship on the planet instantly obsolete.	✓1[X]
26. Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz — Tirpitz passed the German Naval Laws (1898, 1900) to construct a fleet capable of challenging the British Royal Navy in the North Sea.	✓1[X]
27. The Two-Power Standard — Established by the Naval Defence Act 1889, Britain viewed naval supremacy as strictly vital for its food supply and empire.	✓1[X]
28. To build a navy so strong that Britain would not risk a battle for fear of crippling itself — Tirpitz believed this would force Britain to make diplomatic concessions and grant Germany colonial territory.	✓1[X]
29. “We want eight and we won't wait!” — British public alarm over German naval expansion forced the Liberal government to double its naval construction budget.	✓1[X]
30. The Kiel Canal — Its completion in June 1914 allowed the German fleet to concentrate rapidly, significantly heightening British war fears.	✓1[X]
31. Britain: 29 dreadnoughts; Germany: 17 dreadnoughts — Although Britain won the building race, the naval rivalry destroyed over a century of cordial Anglo-German diplomatic relations.	✓1[X]
32. It wiped out the British advantage in older pre-dreadnought battleships, resetting the naval race to zero — By making older warships obsolete, Germany could compete on equal terms by building only dreadnoughts.	✓1[X]

LESSON 5: ALLIANCE SYSTEM & BALKAN POWDER KEG

33. Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy — The defensive treaty pledged mutual military assistance if any member was attacked by two or more great powers.	✓1[X]
34. Splendid Isolation — Britain focused on its worldwide empire and maintaining the naval balance of power without entangling continental treaties.	✓1[X]
35. The Entente Cordiale — It resolved colonial disputes (Britain in Egypt, France in Morocco) and paved the way for close diplomatic cooperation.	✓1[X]
36. The Anglo-Russian Convention — It ended the century-long 'Great Game' of imperial competition in Asia, clearing the path for joint European alignment.	✓1[X]
37. Italy held deep territorial rivalries with its alliance partner, Austria-Hungary — Italy coveted Italia Irredenta (Trentino and Trieste) ruled by Vienna, leading Italy to declare neutrality in 1914 and switch sides in 1915.	✓1[X]
38. A localized regional quarrel could instantly trigger a continent-wide chain reaction — Pledges of mutual defence meant empires felt compelled to mobilise armies to protect partners, converting a Balkan crisis into World War.	✓1[X]
39. The collapse of the Ottoman Empire created intense Slavic nationalism and imperial rivalries — Austria-Hungary and Russia both competed to dominate newly independent Balkan states like Serbia, creating constant crises.	✓1[X]
40. The Bosnian Crisis (Annexation of Bosnia-Herzegovina) — Austria annexed the Slavic province; Germany forced Russia to back down with a military ultimatum, leaving Russia determined never to back down again.	✓1[X]

LESSON 6: SARAJEVO ASSASSINATION & JULY CRISIS

41. 28 June 1914 — The Archduke, heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne, was visiting the Bosnian capital on Vidovdan (St Vitus' Day), a Serbian national holiday.	✓1[X]
42. Gavrilo Princip — Princip was a member of Young Bosnia, a revolutionary student movement seeking to unite South Slavs into a Greater Serbia.	✓1[X]
43. The Black Hand (Union or Death) — Led by Colonel Dragutin Dimitrijević ('Apis'), head of Serbian military intelligence, who smuggled weapons and bombs across the border.	✓1[X]
44. Bosnia contained a large ethnic Serb population that Serbia wanted to incorporate into a Greater Serbian state — The 1908 Bosnian Crisis humiliated Serbia and its protector Russia, establishing a bitter blood-feud with Vienna.	✓1[X]
45. Germany's unconditional promise of total military support to Austria-Hungary against Serbia — Kaiser Wilhelm II and Chancellor Bethmann-Hollweg encouraged Vienna to strike quickly, gambling that Russia would back down.	✓1[X]
46. The Austro-Hungarian Ultimatum (The Ten Demands) — Deliberately designed to be rejected, it demanded Austrian police enter Serbian sovereign territory to investigate the murder.	✓1[X]
47. The Schlieffen Plan — Conceived by Count von Schlieffen, it planned to conquer France in 6 weeks via	✓1[X]

THE SEVEN CRUCIAL PROTAGONISTS (1871–1914)

Otto von Bismarck • Imperial Chancellor of Germany (1871–1890)

Engineered German unification through "Blood and Iron"; constructed the Triple Alliance and Reinsurance Treaty to isolate France and prevent a two-front war.

Kaiser Wilhelm II • German Emperor (1888–1918)

Impulsive autocrat; dismissed Bismarck (1890), dropped the Russian treaty, championed aggressive Weltpolitik, and gave Austria the fatal Blank Cheque (1914).

Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz • State Secretary of the German Imperial Navy

Authored the German Naval Laws (1898/1900) and "Risk Theory"; directed High Seas Fleet construction that triggered the naval arms race with Great Britain.

Archduke Franz Ferdinand • Heir to the Austro-Hungarian Throne

Targeted by Serbian extremists for his reformist views; his assassination on 28 June 1914 in Sarajevo was the catalytic spark for the outbreak of war.

Gavrilo Princip • Serbian Nationalist Assassin (Young Bosnia / Black Hand)

19-year-old student operative who fired the fatal shots in Sarajevo to break the South Slav provinces away from Austria-Hungary into a Greater Serbia.

Sir Edward Grey • British Foreign Secretary (1905–1916)

Attempted international mediation during the July Crisis; delivered the British ultimatum to Germany to defend Belgian neutrality under the 1839 Treaty of London.

Helmuth von Moltke (the Younger) • Chief of the German General Staff

Executed the Schlieffen Plan; argued that Russian mobilisation meant Germany had to launch an immediate pre-emptive invasion of France via Belgium.

ACADEMIC VOCABULARY WITH SPOKEN PRONUNCIATION GUIDE

Weltpolitik [Velt-pol-ee-teek] (GERMAN)

"World Policy." Kaiser Wilhelm II's assertive foreign policy seeking global colonies, international prestige, and naval supremacy matching Britain.

Revanche [Ruh-vahnsh] (FRENCH)

"Revenge." The profound, enduring French national desire to avenge defeat in the Franco-Prussian War (1870–71) and reclaim Alsace-Lorraine.

Realpolitik [Ray-ahl-pol-ee-teek] (GERMAN)

Pragmatic, hard-nosed statecraft based on practical power and national self-interest rather than moral or ideological ideals.

HMS Dreadnought [Dred-nawt] (ENGLISH)

Revolutionary 1906 British battleship with all-big-gun armament and steam turbines, rendering all previous battleships instantly obsolete.

Entente Cordiale [Ahn-tahnt Kor-dyahl] (FRENCH)

"Cordial Understanding." 1904 diplomatic accord resolving colonial disputes between Britain and France, paving the way for joint military talks.

Blank Cheque (Blankoscheck) [Blaahnk-oh-sheck] (GERMAN)

Germany's unconditional pledge of military backing given to Austria-Hungary on 5–6 July 1914, emboldening Vienna to declare war on Serbia.

Mobilisation [Moh-bi-ly-zay-shun] (MILITARY)

The complex, timetable-driven movement of reserves, troops, and supplies to frontiers via railways; once ordered, it made war unstoppable.

The Powder Keg of Europe (METAPHOR)

The volatile Balkan peninsula where competing ethnic Slavic nationalisms and Austro-Russian imperial rivalries threatened continental peace.

SUMMATIVE ASSESSMENT ENQUIRY QUESTION:

“Why did the First World War break out in August 1914?”

1. THE M.A.I.N. STRUCTURAL CAUSES & THE JULY SPARK

Militarism: Anglo-German dreadnought naval race; massive army expansions; rigid railway mobilisation timetables (Schlieffen Plan).

Alliances: Triple Alliance (Ger, Aus, Ita) vs. Triple Entente (Bri, Fra, Rus); transformed a regional Balkan clash into a world war.

Imperialism: Scramble for Africa; Moroccan Crises (1905, 1911) cemented Anglo-French entente and isolated Germany.

Nationalism: French *Revanche* for Alsace-Lorraine; Pan-Slavism & Serbian nationalism in the Balkans (The Black Hand).

The Catalyst (The July Crisis): Sarajevo assassination (28 June) → German Blank Cheque (5 July) → Austrian Ultimatum (23 July) → Russian mobilisation (30 July) → German invasion of neutral Belgium (4 August).

2. HISTORIOGRAPHICAL VERDICT: COMPETING INTERPRETATIONS

Fritz Fischer Thesis (German Aggression):
Germany's imperial leaders deliberately exploited the Sarajevo crisis, issuing the Blank Cheque to launch a pre-emptive war for European continental hegemony.

Christopher Clark Thesis ('The Sleepwalkers'):
No single power sought a world war. European leaders sleepwalked into catastrophe through mutual paranoia, miscalculation, and rigid alliance treaties.

3. MASTER ANALYTICAL SENTENCE STARTERS & CAUSAL CONNECTIVES

- “On one hand, orthodox historians argue that German aggressive foreign policy...”
- “This directly escalated tensions because Wilhelm II’s pursuit of Weltpolitik...”
- “Consequently, the Sarajevo assassination acted as the fatal catalyst because...”
- “However, revisionist historians like Christopher Clark emphasize that the Alliance System...”
- “In conclusion, while M.A.I.N. created the combustible structural conditions, the decisive spark was...”